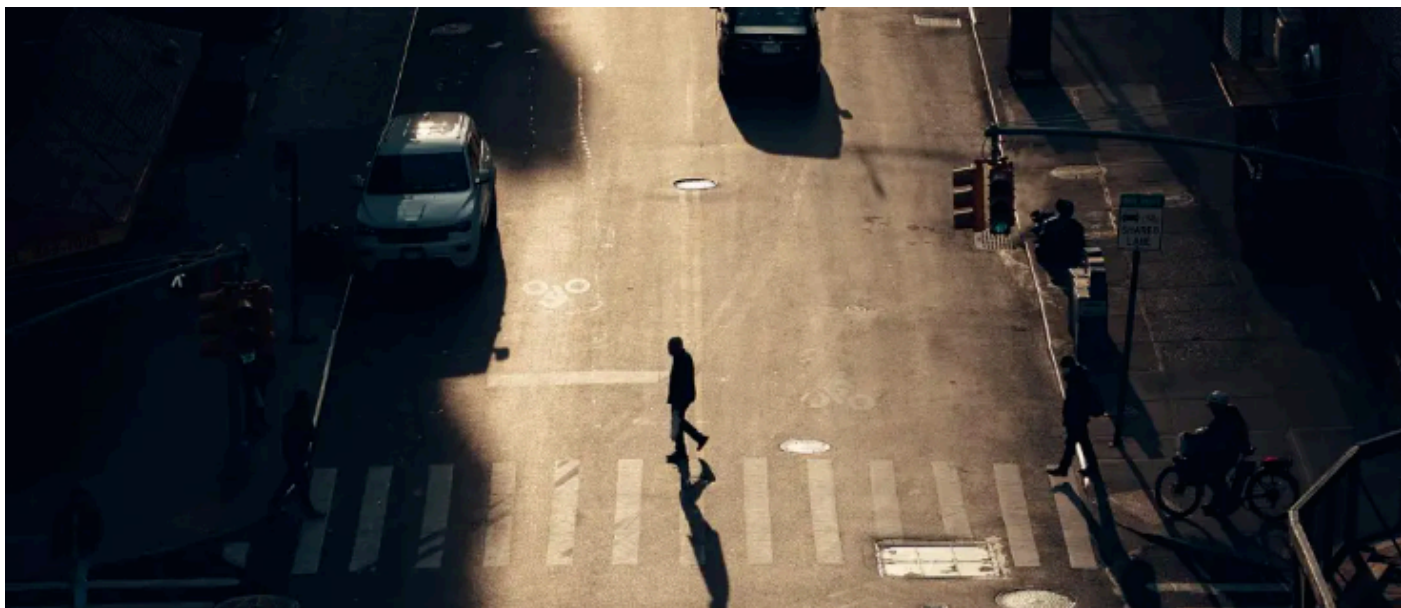




为什么时间管理正在毁掉我们的生活？

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2025/12/08

≡ 分类

时间管理

≡ 简述

光是意识到时间不够用，就足以引发
虑，进而影响发挥

≡ 声明

仅供学习交流使用，非商业使用，..

≡ 备注

Oliver Burkeman | www.theguardian.co

<https://flowus.cn/preview/5519036b-9072-40f8-86a2-74d8ad829f3e>



The eternal human struggle to live meaningfully in the face of inevitable death entered its newest phase one Monday in the summer of 2007, when employees of Google gathered to hear a talk by a writer and self-avowed geek named Merlin Mann. Their biggest professional problem was email, the digital

blight that was colonising more and more of their hours, squeezing out time for more important work, or for having a life. And Mann, a rising star of the “personal productivity” movement, seemed like he might have found the answer.

人类在无法避免的死亡面前，永恒地追求着生活的意义。在 2007 年夏天的一个周一迎来了新动向。那天谷歌员工聚在一起，听一位名叫梅林·曼恩的作家演讲，这人还自称“极客”。他们工作中最大的麻烦就是邮件：这东西堪称数字时代的顽疾，占满了越来越多时间，把做重要工作、过正常生活的空隙都挤没了。而曼恩作为“个人效率”运动里冉冉升起的红人，那会儿似乎找到了破解之道。

He called his system “Inbox Zero”, and the basic idea was simple enough. Most of us get into bad habits with email: we check our messages every few minutes, read them and feel vaguely stressed about them, but take little or no action, so they pile up into an even more stress-inducing heap. Instead, Mann advised his audience that day at Google’s Silicon Valley campus, every time you visit your inbox, you should

systematically “process to zero”. Clarify the action each message requires – a reply, an entry on your to-do list, or just filing it away. Perform that action. Repeat until no emails remain. Then close your inbox, and get on with living.

他这套方法叫“收件箱清零”，核心思路特别简单。咱们大多数人用邮件都有坏习惯：每隔几分钟就点开看，读完心里隐隐发慌，却几乎不做事，结果邮件越堆越多，更让人焦头烂额。曼恩当天在谷歌硅谷园区跟听众说，每次打开收件箱，都得按规矩“清到零”：先想清楚每封邮件该怎么处理——是回复、记到待办清单里，还是直接归档？该做的赶紧做，循环往复直到收件箱空空如也，然后关掉它，该干啥干啥去。

“It was really just a way of saying, ‘I suck at email, and here’s stuff that makes me suck less at it – you may find it useful,’” Mann recalled later. But he had stumbled on a rich seam of societal anxiety. Hundreds of thousands of people watched his talk online, and Inbox Zero spawned countless blog posts, along with books and apps. It was the Atkins diet for nerds: if you weren’t doing it yourself, you almost certainly knew

someone who was. Mann's followers triumphantly posted screenshots of their empty inboxes; the New Yorker, discerning his increasingly cult-like following, described his system as "halfway between Scientology and Zen". (The New York Post called it bullshit.)“

“说白了就是‘我处理邮件超烂，但这些招能让我没那么烂——你们说不定能用得上’，”曼恩后来回忆道。可他没料到，这正好戳中了全社会的焦虑痛点。几十万人在线看了他的演讲，“收件箱清零”不仅催生了一大堆博客文章，还冒出了相关书籍和应用。这就跟书呆子圈的阿特金斯减肥法似的：你自己没试过，也肯定认识有人在跟风。曼恩的粉丝得意地晒出空收件箱截图；《纽约客》察觉到他越来越多的死忠粉，把这套方法形容成“介于主张控制的科学教与主张放下的禅宗之间”（《纽约邮报》则直接骂它“胡扯”）。

If all this fervour seems extreme – Inbox Zero was just a set of technical instructions for handling email, after all – this was because email had become far more than a technical problem. It functioned as a kind of infinite to-do list, to which

anyone on the planet could add anything at will. For the “knowledge workers” of the digital economy, it was both metaphor and delivery mechanism for the feeling that the pressure of trying to complete an ever-increasing number of tasks, in a finite quantity of time, was becoming impossible to bear.

要是觉得这股狂热有点过头——毕竟“收件箱清零”说白了就是套处理邮件的技巧——那是因为邮件早就不只是个技术问题了。它活脱脱变成了没个尽头的待办清单，地球上任何人都能往里面随便加东西。对于数字经济里的“知识工作者”来说，这东西既像个隐喻，又实实在在传递着一种压力：要在有限时间里做完越来越多的事，这压力实在扛不住了。

Most of us have experienced this creeping sense of being overwhelmed: the feeling not merely that our lives are full of activity – that can be exhilarating – but that time is slipping out of our control. And today, the personal productivity movement that Mann helped launch – which promises to ease the pain with time-management advice tailored to the era of

smartphones and the internet – is flourishing as never before. There are now thousands of apps in the “productivity” category of the Apple app store, including software to simulate the ambient noise of working in a coffee shop (this has been shown, in psychology experiments, to help people focus on work), and a text editor that deletes the words you have written if you don’t keep typing fast enough.

我们大多都有过这种慢慢涌上的窒息感：不是说生活忙点不好——忙起来也能让人兴奋——而是觉得时间悄悄从指缝溜走，根本抓不住。如今曼恩参与发起的个人效率运动，靠着适配智能手机和互联网时代的时间管理技巧缓解这种痛苦，发展得比以往任何时候都火。苹果应用商店的“效率”分类下，现在有几千款应用：比如能模拟咖啡馆环境噪音的软件（心理学实验说这能帮人专注工作），还有款文本编辑器，要是打字速度跟不上，写过的字会自动消失。

The quest for increased personal productivity – for making the best possible use of your limited time – is a dominant motif of our age. Two books on the topic by the New York

Times journalist Charles Duhigg have spent more than 60 weeks on the US bestseller lists between them, and the improbable titular promise of another book, *The Four Hour Work Week*, has seduced a reported 1.35m readers worldwide. There are blogs offering tips on productive dating, and on the potential result of productive dating, productive parenting; signs have been spotted in American hotels wishing visitors a “productive stay”. The archetypal Silicon Valley startup, in the last few years, has been one that promises to free up time and mental capacity by eliminating some irritating “friction” of daily life – shopping or laundry, or even eating, in the case of the sludgy, beige meal replacement Soylent – almost always for the purpose of doing more work.

追求更高的个人效率——也就是把有限时间用到位——成了这个时代的主旋律。《纽约时报》记者查尔斯·杜希格写的两本相关书籍，在美国畅销书排行榜上累计待了60多周；另一本《每周工作四小时》，书名里的承诺听着玄乎，却据说让全球135万人动了心。还有博客教你“高效约会”，甚至教你约会成功后怎么“高效带娃”；美国有些酒店里还贴着标语，祝客人“入住期间事事高效”。这

几年典型的硅谷创业公司，都在琢磨怎么去掉日常生活里那些烦人的“麻烦事”——比如购物、洗衣，甚至吃饭（就像那款口感黏糊糊、米白色的代餐食品 Soylent）——目的几乎都是为了让人能多干活，省出时间、腾出脑子。

And yet the truth is that more often than not, techniques designed to enhance one's personal productivity seem to exacerbate the very anxieties they were meant to allay. The better you get at managing time, the less of it you feel that you have. Even when people did successfully implement Inbox Zero, it didn't reliably bring calm. Some interpreted it to mean that every email deserved a reply, which only shackled them more firmly to their inboxes. ("That drives me crazy," Mann says.) Others grew jumpy at the thought of any messages cluttering an inbox that was supposed to stay pristine, and so ended up checking more frequently. My own dismaying experience with Inbox Zero was that becoming hyper-efficient at processing email meant I ended up getting more email: after all, it's often the case that replying to a

message generates a reply to that reply, and so on. (By contrast, negligent emailers often discover that forgetting to reply brings certain advantages: people find alternative solutions to the problems they were nagging you to solve, or the looming crisis they were emailing about never occurs.)

可事实是，很多时候这些提升效率的技巧，偏偏把原本要缓解的焦虑弄得更厉害。你越会管理时间，越觉得时间不够用。就算真有人做到了“收件箱清零”，也未必能让人踏实下来。有些人觉得这意味着每封邮件都得回，结果反而被收件箱绑得更紧（“这简直让我抓狂，”曼恩说）。另一些人一想到本该干干净净的收件箱要被邮件弄脏，就坐立不安，最后查邮件更勤了。我自己试“收件箱清零”的经历就挺闹心：处理邮件变得超高效，结果收到的邮件反而更多了——毕竟回复一封，往往会引来另一封回复，循环往复没个完。（反观那些不爱回邮件的人，常会发现忘了回复还有意外好处：别人要么自己找到办法解决了原本缠着让你搞定的问题，要么邮件里说的“大危机”根本就没发生。）

The allure of the doctrine of time management is that, one day, everything might finally be under control. Yet work in the modern economy is notable for its limitlessness. And if the stream of incoming emails is endless, Inbox Zero can never bring liberation: you're still Sisyphus, rolling his boulder up that hill for all eternity – you're just rolling it slightly faster.

时间管理那套说法之所以吸引人，是因为它让人觉得，总有一天一切都能掌控住。可现代职场的特点就是没个边界——活儿永远干不完。要是邮件像流水一样不断涌进来，“收件箱清零”根本带不来真正的解脱：你仍是推石上山的西西弗斯，永无止境——无非是推得快了些罢了。

Two years after his Google talk, Mann released a rambling and slightly manic online video in which he announced that he had signed a contract for an Inbox Zero book. But his career as a productivity guru had begun to stir an inner conflict. “I started making pretty good money from it” – from speaking and consulting – “but I also started to feel terrible,” he told me earlier this year. “This topic of productivity

induces the worst kind of procrastination, because it feels like you're doing work, but I was producing stuff that had the express purpose of saying to people, 'Look, come and see how to do your work, rather than doing your work!'"

在谷歌做分享两年后，曼恩发了段东拉西扯又略带亢奋的线上视频，说自己签了本《收件箱清零》的出书合同。可这份“效率大师”的差事，反倒让他心里拧成了疙瘩。“靠演讲和咨询，我确实赚了不少钱，”今年早些时候他跟我说，“但心里越来越不是滋味。效率这话题，偏偏催生最要命的拖延症——你明明觉得自己在干活，可我写的那些东西，明摆着就是想告诉大家：‘来学怎么干活啊，别真去干活！’”

The book missed its publication date. Fans started asking questions. Then, after two more years, Mann published a self-lacerating essay in which he abruptly announced that he was jettisoning the project. It was the 3,000-word howl of a man who had suddenly grasped the irony of missing morning after morning with his three-year-old daughter because he was “typing bullshit that I hoped would please my book editor”

about how to use time well. He was guilty, he declared, of “abandoning [my] priorities to write about priorities ... I’ve unintentionally ignored my own counsel to never let your hard work fuck up the good things.” He hinted that he might write a different kind of book instead – a book about stuff that really mattered – but it never appeared. “I’m mostly out of the productivity racket these days,” Mann told me. “If you’re just using efficiency to jam more and more stuff into your day ... well, how would you ever know that that’s working?”

这本书没能按时出版，粉丝们开始追问。又过了两年，曼恩发表了一篇痛斥自己的文章，突然宣布搁置这个项目。这三千字的宣泄，活脱脱是一个男人幡然醒悟后的呐喊：他每天早上都在“敲些糊弄编辑的空话，就为了讨图书编辑开心”，内容全是“如何管好时间”，却偏偏错过了和三岁女儿相处的时光——这本身就是天大的讽刺。他坦言自己犯了个荒唐错：“为了写‘人生优先级’的文章，反倒把自己的人生优先级抛到了脑后……我亲手违背了自己的告诫：别让辛苦工作，搅黄了身边的美好。”他还暗示，或许会写本不一样的书——一本讲真正重要的事的书——可最后也没下文了。“这些年我基本淡出效率圈

了,”曼恩说,“要是你只是靠效率,把一天塞得满满当当……那你怎么知道,这么做真的有用?”

It's understandable that we respond to the ratcheting demands of modern life by trying to make ourselves more efficient. But what if all this efficiency just makes things worse?

现代生活的压力越来越大,我们想靠提高效率扛过去,这件事能理解。可万一,所有这些“高效”,反倒把事情搞得更糟了呢?

Given that the average lifespan consists of only about 4,000 weeks, a certain amount of anxiety about using them well is presumably inevitable: we've been granted the mental capacities to make infinitely ambitious plans, yet almost no time at all to put them into practice. The problem of how to manage time, accordingly, goes back at least to the first century AD, when the Roman philosopher Seneca wrote *On The Shortness of Life*. “This space that has been granted to us rushes by so speedily, and so swiftly that all save a very few

find life at an end just when they are getting ready to live,” he said, chiding his fellow citizens for wasting their days on pointless busyness, and “baking their bodies in the sun”.

说到底，人类平均寿命不过四千周左右，难免会为“如何用好这些时间”焦虑：我们脑子能装下天大的宏图壮志，可落实的时间却少得可怜。所以说，“怎么管时间”这事儿，早能追溯到公元 1 世纪——罗马哲学家塞内卡写过《论生命之短暂》，里面就说：“上天给我们的这点时间，过得飞快，快到绝大多数人刚准备好要好好活，人生就到头了。”他痛斥同乡们把日子浪费在无意义的瞎忙上，“顶着大太阳瞎折腾”，纯属虚度光阴。

Clearly, then, the challenge of how to live our lives well is not a new one. Still, it is safe to say that the citizens of first-century Rome didn't experience the equivalent of today's productivity panic. (Seneca's answer to the question of how to live had nothing to do with becoming more productive: it was to give up the pursuit of wealth or high office, and spend your days philosophising instead.) What is uniquely modern about our fate is that we feel obliged to respond to the pressure of

time by making ourselves as efficient as possible – even when doing so fails to bring the promised relief from stress.

显然，“怎么好好过日子”从来不是新问题。但可以肯定的是，公元 1 世纪的罗马人，从没经历过如今这种“效率焦虑”。（塞内卡给出的生活答案，跟提高效率半毛钱关系都没有：放弃追逐财富和高官厚禄，转而把日子用来钻研哲学。）我们如今的困境之所以特别，在于面对时间压力，总觉得非得拼尽全力提高效率不可——哪怕这么做，根本没能如预期般缓解压力。

Author's Note : It is either impossible, or at least usually feels impossible, to cut down on work in exchange for more time

作者注：想减少工作量换更多时间？要么根本做不到，要么至少看起来是做不到的。

The time-pressure problem was always supposed to get better as society advanced, not worse. In 1930, John Maynard Keynes famously predicted that within a century, economic

growth would mean that we would be working no more than 15 hours per week – whereupon humanity would face its greatest challenge: that of figuring out how to use all those empty hours. Economists still argue about exactly why things turned out so differently, but the simplest answer is “capitalism”. Keynes seems to have assumed that we would naturally throttle down on work once our essential needs, plus a few extra desires, were satisfied. Instead, we just keep finding new things to need. Depending on your rung of the economic ladder, it’s either impossible, or at least usually feels impossible, to cut down on work in exchange for more time.

按理说，随着社会进步，时间压力问题本该缓解，而非恶化。1930 年，约翰·梅纳德·凯恩斯曾做出著名预测：一个世纪之内，经济增长会让我们每周工作不超过 15 小时——到那时，人类将面临最大挑战：怎么打发这些空闲时光。经济学家至今还在争论，事情为啥会差这么多，但最简单的答案就是“资本主义”。凯恩斯似乎觉得，只要基本需求满足了，再加上几个额外愿望也实现了，我们自然会减少工作量。可事实是，我们总在不断发现新的需

求。至于能不能少干活多挤点时间，全看你在经济阶梯上的位置——要么根本不可能，要么至少多半让人觉得不现实。

Arguably the first time management guru – the progenitor of the notion that personal productivity might be the answer to the problem of time pressure – was Frederick Winslow Taylor, an engineer hired in 1898 by the Bethlehem Steel Works, in Pennsylvania, with a mandate to improve the firm's efficiency. “Staring out over an industrial yard that covered several square miles of the Pennsylvania landscape, he watched as labourers loaded 92lb [iron bars] on to rail cars,” writes Matthew Stewart, in his book *The Management Myth*. “There were 80,000 tons' worth of iron bars, which were to be carted off as fast as possible to meet new demand sparked by the Spanish-American war. Taylor narrowed his eyes: there was waste here, he was certain.”

要说第一位时间管理大师，那得是弗雷德里克·温斯洛·泰勒——正是他最先提出，个人效率或许能解决时间压力问题。1898年，宾夕法尼亚州的伯利恒钢铁厂雇了他

当工程师，任务就是提高公司效率。马修·斯图尔特在《管理神话》里写道：“他望着宾夕法尼亚州那片占地好几平方英里的厂区，看着工人们把 92 磅重的铁条装上火车车厢。这些铁条总共 8 万吨，得赶紧运走——美西战争催生了新需求，必须抓紧赶工。泰勒眯起眼睛：这里面肯定有浪费。”

The Bethlehem workers, Taylor calculated, were shifting about 12.5 tons of iron per man per day – but predictably, when he offered a group of “large, powerful Hungarians” some extra cash to work as fast as they could for an hour, he found that they performed much better. Extrapolating to a full work day, and guesstimating time for breaks, Taylor concluded, with his trademark blend of self-confidence and woolly maths, that every man ought to be shifting 50 tons per day – four times their usual amount.

泰勒算过，伯利恒的工人平均每人每天大概能搬 12.5 吨铁。但不出所料，他找了一群“身材高大、力气十足的匈牙利人”，给他们加了点钱，让他们一小时内拼命干，结果发现他们表现好太多了。泰勒从这一小时的表现推算出

全天工作量，再估摸着留些休息时间，最后凭着他那标志性的自信，加上几分粗糙的计算，得出结论：每人每天该搬 50 吨铁——是平时的四倍。

Workers were naturally unhappy at this transparent attempt to pay them the same money for more work, but Taylor was not especially concerned with their happiness; their job was to implement, not understand, his new philosophy of “scientific management”. “One of the very first requirements for a man who is fit to handle pig iron,” wrote Taylor, is “that he shall be so stupid and phlegmatic that he more nearly resembles in his mental makeup the ox than any other type ... he is so stupid that the word ‘percentage’ has no meaning for him.”

这种明摆着要让他们多干活却不多给钱的做法，工人们自然不乐意。可泰勒压根不在乎他们高不高兴——他们的活儿是执行，不是理解他那套新的“科学管理”理念。泰勒写道：“一个人要想适合干搬运生铁的活儿，首要条件就是得愚钝又麻木，心智上更像头牛，而不是别的什么……他笨到连‘百分比’三个字都听不懂。”

The idea of efficiency that Taylor sought to impose on Bethlehem Steel was borrowed from the mechanical engineers of the industrial revolution. It was a way of thinking about improving the functioning of machines, now transferred to humans. And it caught on: Taylor enjoyed a high-profile career as a lecturer on the topic, and by 1915, according to the historian Jennifer Alexander, “the word ‘efficiency’ was plastered everywhere – in headlines, advertisements, editorials, business manuals, and church bulletins.” In the first decades of the 20th century, in a Britain panicked by the rise of German power, the National Efficiency movement united politicians on left and right. (“At the present time,” the Spectator noted in 1902, “there is a universal outcry for efficiency in all the departments of society, in all aspects of life.”)

泰勒想给伯利恒钢铁厂灌输的“效率”理念，其实是从工业革命时期的机械工程师那儿借鉴来的。这本来是用来改进机器性能的思路，如今竟套到了人身上。可这理念偏偏火了起来：泰勒靠着宣讲这一主题成了名人，事业做得风

生水起。据历史学家詹妮弗·亚历山大记载，到 1915 年，“效率”这词简直铺天盖地——报纸标题、广告、社论、商业手册，连教堂公告栏上都能见到。20 世纪头几十年，德国的崛起让英国慌了神，一场“国家效率运动”把左右两派政客都拧到了一起。（1902 年《旁观者》杂志就评论道：“眼下，社会各个领域、生活方方面面，人人都在喊着要效率。”）

It is not hard to grasp the appeal: efficiency was the promise of doing what you already did, only better, more cheaply, and in less time. What could be wrong with that? Unless you happened to be on the sharp end of attempts to treat humans like machines – like the workers of Bethlehem Steel – there wasn't an obvious downside.

这种理念的吸引力其实很好理解：效率承诺的是，你该做的事照做，只是做得更好、更省钱、更省时。这有什么不妥呢？除非你恰好沦为被当作机器使唤的对象——就像伯利恒钢铁厂的工人那样——否则压根看不到什么明显的坏处。

But as the century progressed, something important changed: we all became Frederick Winslow Taylors, presiding ruthlessly over our own lives. As the doctrine of efficiency grew entrenched – as the ethos of the market spread to more and more aspects of society, and life became more individualistic – we internalised it. In Taylor's day, efficiency had been primarily a way to persuade (or bully) other people to do more work in the same amount of time; now it is a regimen that we impose on ourselves.

但随着这个世纪慢慢推进，一件重要的事变了：我们都成了弗雷德里克·温斯洛·泰勒，铁面无私地打理着自己的日子。效率至上的理念越来越根深蒂固——市场风气渗透到社会的方方面面，生活也变得越来越个人主义——我们把这套逻辑慢慢刻进了自己的骨子里。泰勒那个年代，效率主要是用来哄着（或者逼着）别人在同样时间里多干活的手段；可现在，它变成了我们强加给自己的规矩。

According to legend, Taylorism first crossed the threshold into personal productivity when Charles Schwab, the president of Bethlehem Steel, asked another consultant, a businessman named Ivy Lee, to improve his executives' efficiency as well. Lee advised those white-collar workers to make nightly to-do lists, arranging tomorrow's six most important tasks by priority, then to start at the top of the list next morning, working down. It's a stretch to imagine that nobody had thought of this before. But the story goes that when Lee told Schwab to test it for three months, then pay him what he thought it was worth, the steel magnate wrote him a cheque worth more than \$400,000 in today's money – and the time management industry was up and running.

相传泰勒制第一次走进个人效率领域，是伯利恒钢铁公司总裁查尔斯·施瓦布请另一位顾问——商人艾维·李——帮忙提升高管效率的时候。李给这些白领支了个招：每晚列个待办清单，把第二天最重要的六件事按轻重缓急排好，第二天早上从头往下做。若说此前竟无人想到此法，恐难令人信服。据说李让施瓦布先试三个月，之后觉得值多少钱就给多少，这位钢铁大亨最后开了一张支票

——换算成现在的钱，居然超过 40 万美元——时间管理这个行业就这么应运而生了。

Author's Note : In an era of insecure employment, we must constantly demonstrate our usefulness through frenetic doing

作者注：就业不稳定的年代，我们得靠拼命干活来不断证明自己有用。

Other gurus were to follow, writing bestsellers that modified Lee's basic technique to incorporate the setting of long-term goals (the 1973 book *How to Get Control of Your Time and Your Life*, by Alan Lakein, who boasted of having advised both IBM and Gloria Steinem, and who inspired a young Bill Clinton) and spiritual values (*The Seven Habits of Highly Effective People*, published in 1989 by the Mormon efficiency expert Stephen Covey).

后来又冒出不少“效率大师”，写的畅销书都在李的基础方法上做了些调整：有的加入了制定长期目标的内容（比如 1973 年艾伦·莱金写的《如何掌控你的时间和人生》，

他号称给 IBM 和格洛丽亚·斯泰纳姆都当过顾问，连年轻时候的比尔·克林顿都受他启发)；有的则融入了精神层面的价值观（比如摩门教效率专家史蒂芬·柯维 1989 年出版的《高效能人士的七个习惯》）。

Time management promised a sense of control in a world in which individuals – decreasingly supported by the social bonds of religion or community – seemed to lack it. In an era of insecure employment, we must constantly demonstrate our usefulness through frenetic doing, and time management can give you a valuable edge. Indeed, if you are among the growing ranks of the self-employed, as a freelancer or a worker in the so-called gig economy, increased personal efficiency may be essential to your survival. The only person who suffers financially if you indulge in “loafing” – a workplace vice that Taylor saw as theft – is you.

现在这世界，宗教和社群的社会联结越来越弱，人们能得到的支撑也越来越少，总觉得心里没着没落。而时间管理，恰恰承诺能让人找回掌控感。就业不稳定的年代，我们得靠拼命忙活不断证明自己有用，这时候时间管理就能

帮你占得先机。尤其是如果你属于日益壮大的自雇群体——不管是自由职业者，还是所谓“零工经济”里的从业者——提高个人效率可能直接关乎你的生存。要是你总爱“摸鱼”（泰勒眼里这就是职场盗窃），最后经济上吃亏的只会是你自己。

Above all, time management promises that a meaningful life might still be possible in this profit-driven environment, as Melissa Gregg explains in *Counterproductive*, a forthcoming history of the field. With the right techniques, the prophets of time management all implied, you could fashion a fulfilling life while simultaneously attending to the ever-increasing demands of your employer. This promise “comes back and back, in force, whenever there’s an economic downturn”, Gregg told me.

最关键的是，时间管理承诺，即便在这个逐利的环境里，有意义的人生依然触手可及。正如梅丽莎·格雷格在即将出版的时间管理史著作《反生产》（*Counterproductive*）中所言，所有时间管理的倡导者都暗示：只要方法得当，你既能应对雇主越来越多的要求，也能经营出充实的生活。

格雷格告诉我，每当经济下行，这种承诺就会“一次次卷土重来，势头更猛”。

Especially at the higher-paid end of the employment spectrum, time management whispers of the possibility of something even more desirable: true peace of mind. “It is possible for a person to have an overwhelming number of things to do and still function productively with a clear head and a positive sense of relaxed control,” the contemporary king of the productivity gurus, David Allen, declared in his 2001 bestseller, *Getting Things Done*. “You can experience what the martial artists call a ‘mind like water’, and top athletes refer to as ‘the zone’.”

尤其在高收入职场人群中，时间管理还隐约预示着一种更珍贵的可能：真正的内心安宁。“一个人就算要处理的事情多到爆棚，也依然能思路清晰、从容掌控节奏，还能高效推进工作，”当代效率大师大卫·艾伦在其 2001 年畅销书《搞定》（*Getting Things Done*）中写道，“你完全可以体验到武术家所说的‘心如止水’，以及顶级运动员口中的‘巅峰状态’。”

As Gregg points out, it is significant that “personal productivity” puts the burden of reconciling these demands squarely on our shoulders as individuals. Time management gurus rarely stop to ask whether the task of merely staying afloat in the modern economy – holding down a job, paying the mortgage, being a good-enough parent – really ought to require rendering ourselves inhumanly efficient in the first place.

正如格雷格所指出的，“个人生产力”这个概念的关键问题在于：它把平衡这些需求的重担，完完全全压在了我们每个人身上。可时间管理专家们却很少停下来想想：在现代经济环境中勉强立足——保住工作、还上房贷、做个合格的父母——这些事，真的需要我们一开始就逼自己达到非人的高效吗？

Besides, on closer inspection, even the lesser promises of time management were not all they appeared to be. An awkward truth about Taylor’s celebrated efficiency drives is that they

were not very successful: Bethlehem Steel fired him in 1901, having paid him vast sums without any clearly detectable impact on its own profits. (One persistent consequence of his schemes was that they seemed promising at first, but left workers too exhausted to function consistently over the long term.)

此外，仔细琢磨就会发现，即便时间管理那些听起来没那么玄乎的好处，也并非表面看上去那般美好。泰勒那套备受推崇的效率改革，藏着个尴尬的真相：根本没成功。1901 年，伯利恒钢铁公司解雇了他——公司付了他一大笔钱，却没给公司利润带来任何明显起色。（他的方案还有个后遗症：起初看着挺靠谱，可长期下来会把工人累垮，根本没法稳定干活。）

Likewise, it remains the frequent experience of those who try to follow the advice of personal productivity gurus – I’m speaking from years of experience here – that a “mind like water” is far from the guaranteed result. As with Inbox Zero, so with work in general: the more efficient you get at ploughing through your tasks, the faster new tasks seem to

arrive. (“Work expands to fill the time available for its completion,” as the British historian C Northcote Parkinson realised way back in 1955, when he coined what would come to be known as Parkinson’s law.)

同样，那些试着照个人效率大师建议做的人——我这可是凭多年经验说话——常有的感受是：“心如止水”远不是板上钉钉的结果。就像“收件箱清零”一样，工作这事儿大体也是如此：你越能高效埋头处理任务，新任务似乎就涌来得越快。（英国历史学家 C·诺斯科特·帕金森早在 1955 年就发现了这一点，他提出了后来广为人知的“帕金森定律”：“工作会自动膨胀，占满所有可用的时间。”）

Then there’s the matter of self-consciousness: virtually every time management expert’s first piece of advice is to keep a detailed log of your time use, but doing so just heightens your awareness of the minutes ticking by, then lost for ever. As for focusing on your long-term goals: the more you do that, the more of your daily life you spend feeling vaguely despondent that you have not yet achieved them. Should you manage to

achieve one, the satisfaction is strikingly brief – then it's time to set a new long-term goal. The supposed cure just makes the problem worse.

还有个“过度关注自身状态”的问题：几乎所有时间管理专家的第一条建议，都是让你详细记录自己的时间花销。可这么做只会让你更敏锐地察觉到时光一分一秒溜走，且一去不返。至于专注长期目标：你越盯着不放，在日常生活中就越会因为还没实现这些目标而隐隐有些沮丧。就算真达成了一个，那种满足感也转瞬即逝——接着就得定下一个长期目标了。这所谓的“解药”，不过是让问题雪上加霜。

There is a historical parallel for all this: it's exactly what happened when the spread of “labour-saving” devices transformed the lives of housewives and domestic servants across Europe and north America from the end of the 19th century. Technology now meant that washing clothes no longer entailed a day bent over a mangle; a vacuum-cleaner could render a carpet spotless in minutes.

这一切都有历史先例：19 世纪末，“省力”设备在欧洲和北美普及开来，彻底改变了家庭主妇和佣人的生活，当时的情况和现在如出一辙。有了科技帮忙，洗衣服再也不用弓着腰在轧布机前忙一整天；吸尘器几分钟就能把地毯吸得一尘不染。

Author's Note : The 2016 Time Matters conference was sparsely attended because it was August, and lots of people were on holiday

作者注：2016 年“Time Matters”那会没多少人参加，毕竟是八月，不少人都在度假呢。

Yet as the historian Ruth Cowan demonstrates in her 1983 book *More Work for Mother*, the result, for much of the 20th century, was not an increase in leisure time among those charged with doing the housework. Instead, as the efficiency of housework increased, so did the standards of cleanliness and domestic order that society came to expect. Now that the living-room carpet could be kept perfectly clean, it had to be;

now that clothes never needed to be grubby, grubbiness was all the more taboo. These days, you can answer work emails in bed at midnight. So should that message you got at 5.30pm really wait till morning for a reply?

但历史学家露丝·考恩在 1983 年的著作《母亲的额外劳作》中指出：20 世纪大半时间里，这事儿的结果是——操持家务的人，休闲时间压根没增加。可家务效率上去了，社会对整洁度和家庭秩序的要求也跟着水涨船高。既然客厅地毯能保持一尘不染，那就得一直干干净净；既然衣服没必要再脏兮兮的，邋遢劲儿就更让人没法容忍了。现在倒好，半夜躺床上都能回工作邮件。那下午五点半收到的消息，真就非得等到第二天早上再回复？

One boiling weekend last summer, the impassioned members of a campaign group named Take Back Your Time gathered in a university lecture hall in Seattle, to further their longstanding mission of “eliminating the epidemic of overwork” – and, in so doing, to explore what it might mean to live a life that is not so focused on personal productivity. The 2016 Time Matters conference was a sparsely attended

affair, in part because, as the organisers conceded, it was August, and lots of people were on holiday, and America's most enthusiastically pro-relaxation organisation was hardly going to complain about that. But it was also because, these days, being even modestly anti-productivity – especially in the US – counts as a subversive stance. It is not the kind of platform that lends itself to glitzy mega-events with generous corporate sponsorship and effective marketing campaigns.

去年夏天一个酷热难耐的周末，“夺回你的时间”(Take Back Your Time) 运动组织的热心成员齐聚西雅图一所大学的阶梯教室。他们要继续践行长期使命——根除过劳顽疾，同时也想探索：不把个人效率当唯一核心的生活，究竟该是什么模样？2016 年的“时间至关重要”(Time Matters) 大会没多少人参加。主办方坦言，一来当时是八月，大家多在休假——作为全美最主张劳逸结合的机构，他们自然不会对此说三道四；但更关键的是，如今哪怕只是稍微抵触“唯效率论”，尤其在美国，都算是叛逆之举。这种理念本就不适合办那种光鲜亮丽的大型活动——毕竟这类活动离不开企业大额赞助和给力的营销推广。

The conference-goers discussed schemes for a four-day working week, for abolishing daylight savings time, for holding elections at the weekend, and generally for making America more like countries such as Italy and Denmark. (To be a critic of America's work culture is to constantly gaze longingly across the Atlantic, at semi-mythical versions of Scandinavia and southern Europe.) But the members of Take Back Your Time were calling for something more radical than merely more time off. They sought to question our whole instrumental attitude towards time – the very idea that “getting more done” ought to be our focus in the first place. “You keep hearing people arguing that more time off might be good for the economy,” said John de Graaf, the not-even-slightly-relaxed 70-year-old filmmaker who is the organisation's driving force. “But why should we have to justify life in terms of the economy? It makes no sense!”

与会者们讨论了各种提议：每周四天工作制、取消夏令时、周末举行选举，总之就是想让美国变得更像意大利、丹麦这类国家。（吐槽美国工作文化的人，总免不了眼巴

巴望着大西洋对岸，向往那些被传得像神话一样的斯堪的纳维亚和南欧国度。）但“夺回你的时间”的成员们想要的可不止是多放几天假。他们要追问的是我们对待时间的根本心态——那种“多干活”本该是首要追求的想法，真的站得住脚吗？“你总能听到有人说，多放假可能对经济有好处，”该组织核心人物、70岁高龄却一点都不“佛系”的电影人约翰·德·格拉夫说道，“可我们凭什么要用经济好坏来评判生活的价值？这简直荒唐透顶！”

One of the sneakier pitfalls of an efficiency-based attitude to time is that we start to feel pressured to use our leisure time “productively”, too – an attitude which implies that enjoying leisure for its own sake, which you might have assumed was the whole point of leisure, is somehow not quite enough. And so we find ourselves, for example, travelling to unfamiliar places not for the sheer experience of travel, but in order to add to our mental storehouse of experiences, or to our Instagram feeds. We go walking or running to improve our health, not for the pleasure of movement; we approach the

tasks of parenthood with a fixation on the successful future adults we hope to create.

以效率为核心的时间观，藏着个挺隐蔽的坑：我们会慢慢觉得，连休闲时间都得“用在刀刃上”。可休闲这事儿，你本来以为核心就是图个乐，现在倒好，好像光享乐还不够似的。就说旅行吧，我们去陌生地方，不是为了体验旅行本身的乐趣，反倒成了给脑子攒阅历、给 INS 添素材；散步跑步是为了养生，而非享受动起来的畅快；就连当爸妈，满脑子想的都是“把孩子培养成未来的成功人士”。

In his 1962 book *The Decline of Pleasure*, the critic Walter Kerr noticed this shift in our experience of time: “We are all of us compelled to read for profit, party for contracts, lunch for contacts ... and stay home for the weekend to rebuild the house.” Even rest and recreation, in a culture preoccupied with efficiency, can only be understood as valuable insofar as they are useful for some other purpose – usually, recuperation, so as to enable more work. (Several conference guests mentioned Arianna Huffington’s current crusade to encourage

people to get more sleep; for her, it seems, the main point of rest is to excel at the office.)

评论家沃尔特·克尔在 1962 年的著作《快乐的衰落》里，早就点出了这种时间体验的转变：“我们都不由自主地为了利益读书，为了签合同应酬，为了拓人脉吃午饭……周末待在家里，也不过是为了修房子。”在一个满脑子都是效率的文化里，连休息和娱乐都得“有用”才算有价值——说白了就是养精蓄锐，好接着干活。（好几场会议的参会者都提到，阿里安娜·赫芬顿现在正大力倡导多睡觉；在她看来，休息的核心目的，恐怕还是为了在工作上拔尖。）

If all this increased efficiency brings none of the benefits it was supposed to bring, what should we be doing instead? At Take Back Your Time, the consensus was that personal lifestyle changes would never suffice: reform would have to start with policies on vacation, maternity leave and overtime. But in the meantime, we might try to get more comfortable with not being as efficient as possible – with declining certain opportunities, disappointing certain people, and letting certain

tasks go undone. Plenty of unpleasant chores are essential to survival. But others are not – we have just been conditioned to assume that they are. It isn't compulsory to earn more money, achieve more goals, realise our potential on every dimension, or fit more in. In a quiet moment in Seattle, Robert Levine, a social psychologist from California, quoted the environmentalist Edward Abbey: “Growth for the sake of growth is the ideology of the cancer cell.”

要是这些所谓的“效率提升”，压根没带来当初承诺的好处，那我们该咋办？在“夺回你的时间”这场活动上，大家一致认为：光改个人生活方式没用，改革得从休假、产假、加班制度这些政策入手。但眼下，我们或许可以试着接受“不用事事追求高效”——比如推掉些机会，让有些人失望，有些事儿干脆放着不做。确实，不少糟心的杂活是生存必需，但更多其实不是——只是我们习惯了觉得“非做不可”。赚钱不用非得越多越好，目标不用非得越满越好，也不用逼自己在所有领域都发挥潜能，更不用硬塞一堆事儿给自己。在西雅图一个安静的时刻，加州社会心理学家罗伯特·莱文引用了环保主义者爱德华·艾比的话：“为了增长而增长，正是癌细胞的生存逻辑。”

Yet if the ethos of efficiency and productivity risks prioritising the health of the economy over the happiness of humans, it is also true that the sense of pressure it fosters is not much good for business, either. This, it turns out, is a lesson business is not especially keen to learn.

不过话说回来，要是效率至上、生产力优先的理念，真把经济发展看得比人的幸福感还重，那它催生的压力感，对企业而言其实也没什么好处。可事实是，企业压根没太当回事这个道理。

“After years of consulting with Microsoft, I was suddenly *persona non grata*,” Tom DeMarco told me, with a note of amusement in his voice. DeMarco is a minor legend in the world of software engineering. He began his career at Bell Telephone Labs, birthplace of the laser and transistor, and later became an expert in managing complex software projects, a field notorious for spiralling costs, missed deadlines, and clashing egos. But then, in the 1980s, he

committed heresy: he started arguing that ramping up the time pressure on your employees was a terrible way to drive such projects forward. What was needed, he had come to realise, was not an increased focus on using time efficiently. It was the opposite: more slack.

“给微软做了好几年咨询，我突然就成了不受待见的人，”汤姆·德马科跟我说话时，语气里带着点自嘲的笑意。这位在软件工程界小有名气的传奇人物，职业生涯是从贝尔电话实验室起步的——那儿可是激光和晶体管的诞生地。后来他成了复杂软件项目管理的专家，而这个领域向来以成本飙涨、工期延误、人事内耗闻名。但到了 20 世纪 80 年代，他却发表了“异端言论”：他开始主张，给员工加码时间压力，是推进这类项目最糟糕的办法。他慢慢意识到，真正需要的不是更注重时间利用效率，恰恰相反，是要留更多弹性空间。

Author's Note : Thinking about time encourages clockwatching, which has been repeatedly shown to undermine the quality of work

作者注：总惦记着时间，容易让人老盯着表——研究反复证明，这会拉低工作质量。

“The best companies I visited, all through the years, were never very hurried,” DeMarco said. “Maybe they used pressure from time to time, as a sort of amusing side-effect. But it was never a constant. Because you don’t get creativity for free. You need people to be able to sit back, put their feet up, and think.” Manual work can be speeded up, at least to a certain extent, by increasing the time pressure on workers. But good ideas do not emerge more rapidly when people feel under the gun – if anything, the good ideas dry up.

“这些年我走访过的优秀公司，从来不会火急火燎，”德马科说，“他们或许偶尔会用用压力，但权当是个有趣的小插曲，绝不会当成常态。因为创造力这东西，不是白来的。你得让员工能静下心来，哪怕翘着二郎腿发发呆、捋捋思路。”增加时间压力，或许能在一定程度上加快体力劳动的进度，但人要是被逼得喘不过气，好点子反而会断供——非但不会更快冒出来，反而会彻底枯竭。

Part of the problem is simply that thinking about time encourages clockwatching, which has been repeatedly shown in studies to undermine the quality of work. In one representative experiment from 2008, US researchers asked people to complete the Iowa gambling task, a venerable decision-making test that involves selecting playing cards in order to win a modest amount of cash. All participants were given the same time in which to complete the task – but some were told that time would probably be sufficient, while others were warned it would be tight. Contrary to an intuition cherished especially among journalists – that the pressure of deadlines is what forces them to produce high-quality work – the second group performed far less well. The mere awareness of their limited time triggered anxious emotions that got in the way of performance.

问题的关键在于，总惦记着时间，人就容易老看表，而研究早就反复证实，这会直接拉低工作质量。2008 年就有这么一项代表性实验：美国研究人员让参与者完成“爱荷华赌博任务”——这是个老牌决策测试，参与者要通过选

扑克牌赢点小钱。所有人的任务时长都一样，但一部分人被告知“时间应该够用”，另一部分则被警告“时间会很吃紧”。结果和记者圈里特别流行的一种执念完全相反——他们总觉得截稿期的压力能逼着他们拿出好稿子——但实际上，被告知时间紧张的那组表现差了一大截。光是意识到时间不够用，就足以引发焦虑，进而影响发挥。

But worse perils await. DeMarco points out that any increase in efficiency, in an organisation or an individual life, necessitates a trade-off: you get rid of unused expanses of time, but you also get rid of the benefits of that extra time. A visit to your family doctor provides an obvious example. The more efficiently they manage their time, the fuller their schedule will be – and the more likely it is that you will be kept sitting in the waiting room when an earlier appointment overruns. (That’s all a queue is, after all: the cost of someone else’s efficiency, being shouldered by you.) In the accident and emergency department, by contrast, remaining “inefficient” in this sense is a matter of life and death. If there is an exclusive focus on using the staff’s time as efficiently as

possible, the result will be a department too busy to accommodate unpredictable arrivals, which are the whole reason it exists.

但更棘手的麻烦还在后面。德马科指出，不管是组织运作还是个人生活，任何效率提升都总得有所取舍：你固然甩掉了闲置的大块时间，却也丢了这些额外时间能带来的好处。去看家庭医生就是个明摆着的例子。医生把时间安排得越紧凑高效，日程表就越满——一旦前面的预约超时，你就越可能在候诊室里干等。（说到底，排队这事儿本质很简单：别人的高效成本，最后全落到你头上。）可在急诊科，这种“低效”却是生死攸关的事。要是一门心思只想着让员工时间利用最大化，结果只会让急诊科忙到腾不出手，根本接不住那些突发就诊的病人——而这恰恰是急诊科存在的意义啊。

A similar problem afflicts any corporate cost-cutting exercise that focuses on maximising employees' efficiency: the more of their hours that are put to productive use, the less available they will be to respond, on the spur of the moment, to critical

new demands. For that kind of responsiveness, idle time must be built into the system.

企业里那些一心想让员工效率最大化的降本举措，也会遇到同样的麻烦：员工花在生产性工作上的时间越多，临时接到紧急需求时就越难快速应对。要想有这种灵活响应的能力，系统里得留足空闲时间。

“An organisation that can accelerate but not change direction is like a car that can speed up but not steer,” DeMarco writes. “In the short run, it makes lots of progress in whatever direction it happened to be going. In the long run, it’s just another road wreck.” He often uses the analogy of those sliding number puzzles, in which you move eight tiles around a nine-tile grid, until all the digits are in order. To use the available space more efficiently, you could always add a ninth tile to the empty square. You just wouldn’t be able to solve the puzzle any more. If that jammed and unsolvable puzzle feels like an appropriate metaphor for your life, it’s hard to see how improving your personal efficiency – trying to force yet more tiles on to the grid – is going to be much help.

德马科写道：“一个只会提速、不会转向的组织，就跟一辆能踩油门、不能打方向盘的车一样。短期内不管往哪个方向开，都能冲得挺远；可长远来看，到头来不过是路上的一堆残骸。”他常拿滑块数字谜打比方：在九宫格里移动八个数字块，直到所有数字按顺序排好。要是想更高效利用空间，你大可以在空格里再放第九块数字——可这么一来，这谜题就彻底解不开了。要是你觉得这卡壳又无解的谜题，恰好戳中了你的人生现状，那真看不出提高个人效率有啥用——毕竟这不过是硬往九宫格里再塞更多数字块罢了。

At the very bottom of our anxious urge to manage time better – the urge driving Frederick Winslow Taylor, Merlin Mann, me and perhaps you – it’s not hard to discern a familiar motive: the fear of death. As the philosopher Thomas Nagel has put it, on any meaningful timescale other than human life itself – that of the planet, say, or the cosmos – “we will all be dead any minute”. No wonder we are so drawn to the problem of how to make better use of our days: if we could solve it, we could avoid the feeling, in Seneca’s words, of finding life at

an end just when we were getting ready to live. To die with the sense of nothing left undone: it's nothing less than the promise of immortality by other means.

我们总急着想要把时间管理得更好——这种念头推着弗雷德里克·温斯洛·泰勒、梅林·曼、我，说不定还有你往前跑——往根儿上挖，其实是个老熟人在作祟：对死亡的恐惧。哲学家托马斯·内格尔说得好，要是跳出人类生命这个时间维度，换成地球或者宇宙这种有意义的尺度来看——“我们随时都可能完蛋”。难怪大家都铆着劲儿琢磨怎么把日子过明白：要是真能搞定这事儿，就能躲开塞内卡说的那种无奈——刚准备好好活一场，人生却到头了。带着“没啥遗憾”的感觉离开人世：这说白了，就是换种方式追求永生啊。

But the modern zeal for personal productivity, rooted in Taylor's philosophy of efficiency, takes things several significant steps further. If only we could find the right techniques and apply enough self-discipline, it suggests, we could know that we were fitting everything important in, and could feel happy at last. It is up to us – indeed, it is our

obligation – to maximise our productivity. This is a convenient ideology from the point of view of those who stand to profit from our working harder, and our increased capacity for consumer spending. But it also functions as a form of psychological avoidance. The more you can convince yourself that you need never make difficult choices – because there will be enough time for everything – the less you will feel obliged to ask yourself whether the life you are choosing is the right one.

可现代人对个人效率的痴迷，根子在泰勒的效率哲学里，还把这事儿往极端里推了好几步。这想法说，只要找对法子、够自律，就能把所有要紧事都顾到，最后总算能开心起来。提高效率这事儿，全在我们自己——说白了，这就是我们的本分。那些能从我们多干活、多花钱里捞好处的人，肯定觉得这说法特合心意。但这其实也是一种心理逃避：你越能骗自己不用做那些难选的决定——反正时间够用来做所有事——就越懒得琢磨，自己选的日子到底对不对劲儿。

Personal productivity presents itself as an antidote to busyness when it might better be understood as yet another form of busyness. And as such, it serves the same psychological role that busyness has always served: to keep us sufficiently distracted that we don't have to ask ourselves potentially terrifying questions about how we are spending our days. "How we labour at our daily work more ardently and thoughtlessly than is necessary to sustain our life because it is even more necessary not to have leisure to stop and think," wrote Friedrich Nietzsche, in what reads like a foreshadowing of our present circumstances. "Haste is universal because everyone is in flight from himself."

大家都说个人效率能治忙碌，可其实说它是另一种忙碌，反倒更贴切。所以它跟忙碌的作用没两样：让我们忙得没空想那些吓人的问题——我们这一天天，到底是怎么过的。“我们干活儿一天比一天卖力，也一天比一天没脑子，其实根本用不着这么拼——就因为我们更怕有空停下来琢磨事儿。”弗里德里希·尼采这话，读着就像提前说透了我们现在的处境。“人人都慌慌张张的，说到底，都是在躲自己。”

You can seek to impose order on your inbox all you like – but eventually you'll need to confront the fact that the deluge of messages, and the urge you feel to get them all dealt with, aren't really about technology. They're manifestations of larger, more personal dilemmas. Which paths will you pursue, and which will you abandon? Which relationships will you prioritise, during your shockingly limited lifespan, and who will you resign yourself to disappointing? What matters?

你想怎么整理收件箱都行 —— 但最后总得面对：邮件堆得像山，你急着要全部处理完，这事儿跟技术没啥关系。这背后藏着的，是更大、更关乎自己的难题。该选哪条路，又该放下哪条？这辈子短得吓人，哪些关系要放在前头，又得甘心让谁失望？到底啥才重要？

For Merlin Mann, consciously confronting these questions was a matter of realising that people would always be making more claims on his time – worthy claims, too, for the most part – than it would be possible for him to meet. And that

even the best, most efficient system for managing the emails they sent him was never going to provide a solution to that. “Eventually, I realised something,” he told me. “Email is not a technical problem. It’s a people problem. And you can’t fix people.”

对梅林·曼来说，主动去面对这些问题，才让他明白：总有人要占用他的时间，提的要求大多还挺合理，可他根本顾不过来。就算有再好、再高效的邮件管理系统，也解决不了这事儿。“最后我总算想通了，”他跟我说，“邮件根本不是技术问题，是人出了问题。可人哪是能随便改变的呢？”

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